RETURN TO TRAINING AFTER A MAJOR KNEE INJURY: PLAYER A-74AF

A-74af reported a major right-knee injury on Thursday 25 March 2021. She trained at zero load the following week and was back to her pre-injury weekly load by week +3. Her injury record shows a single day. The case shows why staff need to record availability, not just symptoms.

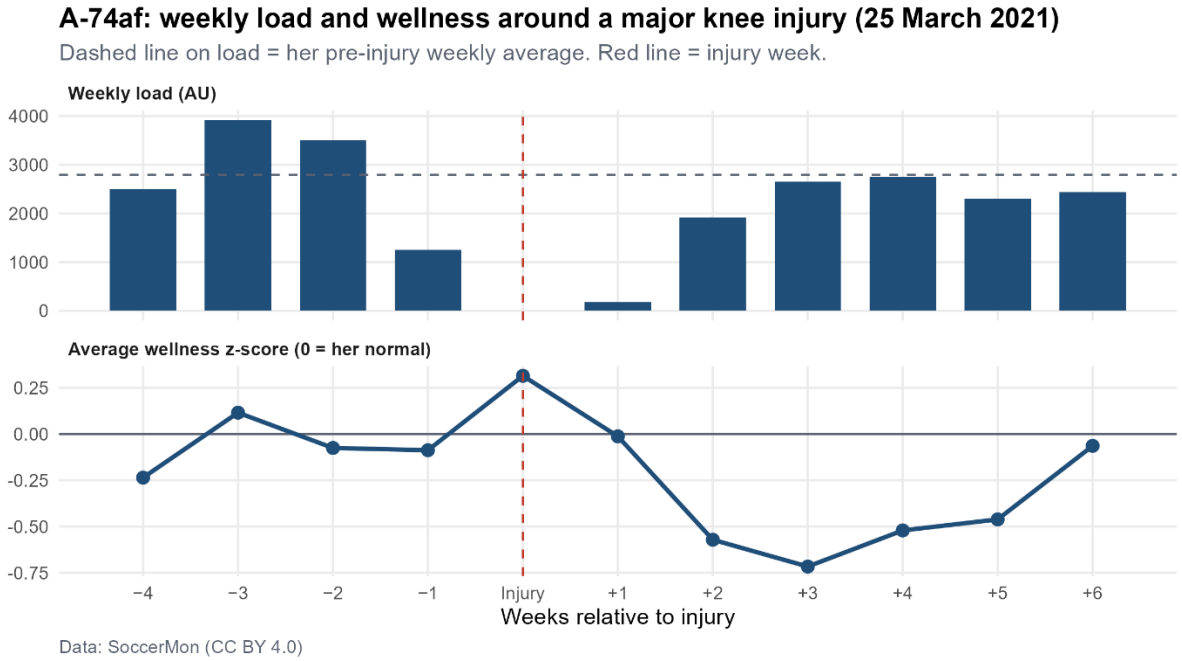


Figure 1. Weekly load and wellness for A-74af, four weeks before to six weeks after her injury (weeks run Monday to Sunday).

Table 1. A-74af's weekly load, ACWR and wellness around the injury.

Week	Week starting	Load (AU)	% of pre-injury load	Training days	ACWR	Wellness (z)
Week −4	22 Feb	2,500	90%	6	0.73	−0.24
Week −3	1 Mar	3,920	140%	6	1.11	0.12
Week −2	8 Mar	3,500	125%	6	1.04	−0.08
Week −1	15 Mar	1,250	45%	3	0.45	−0.09
Injury week	**22 Mar**	**0**	**0%**	**0**	**0.00**	**0.32**
Week +1	29 Mar	180	6%	1	0.15	−0.01
Week +2	5 Apr	1,920	69%	7	**2.29**	**−0.57**
Week +3	12 Apr	2,650	95%	7	**2.23**	**−0.72**
Week +4	19 Apr	2,760	99%	6	1.47	**−0.52**
Week +5	26 Apr	2,310	83%	6	0.96	−0.46
Week +6	3 May	2,440	87%	5	0.96	−0.06

What Happened:

In the four weeks before injury, A-74af trained at an average of 2793 AU a week, with wellness close to her normal (average -0.07, where 0 = her normal). Her load already dropped in week -1 (1250 AU over 3 training days, 45% of her average), and she didn't train at all in the injury week, including the three days before she reported the injury. The data doesn't say why: it could be a planned break, or the problem may have started before it was reported. On 25 March she logged one major right-knee injury report and no further injury reports followed. Without the load data, the record would suggest a one-day problem.

The Return:

After 180 AU in week +1, her load rose more than tenfold to 1920 AU in week +2 and reached 2650 AU (95% oh her pre-injury average) in week +3. Because she has done almost no training for three weeks, her 28-day baseline was very low, so this rapid increase took her ACWR from 2.2.9 and 2.2 at the end of weeks +2 and +3. That is well above the 1.5 danger line, at the point she was coming back from a major injury. Her load then settled at 83-99% of her previous level, and her ACWR fell to 1.47 in week +4 and 0.96 in weeks +5 and +6.

Wellness

Her wellness was close to her normal in the four weeks before injury)between -0.24 and +0.12) and slightly above normal in the injury week (+0.32). It fell when she returned to training: below the -0.5 flag thresholds in weeks +2, +3 and +4 (-0.57, -0.72 and -0.52), the same weeks her ACWR was highest, and recovered to -0.06 by week +6. This matches the squad-wide results: wellness gave no warning before the injury but did respond to the sharp rise in load afterwards. She complete all 7 wellness reports every week, so the picture is complete.

What I'd Monitor Next Time

- A daily availability status (full, modified, unavailable), so the record shows time lost and why she wasn't training.
- A planned return with weekly load targets agreed with the physio, building gradually rather than jumping from almost nothing to near-full load in just two weeks, with ACWR checked each week.
- Wellness and knee symptoms every day of the return. Here, the weekly report would have flagged her as both high ACWR and low wellness in weeks +2 and +4.
- The date she returns to full training, so we can measure return-to-play time across the whole squad.

This is one player's self-reported data, without medical details. It illustrates a monitoring gap; it is not evidence about knee injury recovery more generally.